

ONE-MAN INDUSTRY
Mahanta's carves for
the table



A Cut Above the Rest

A craftsman from Assam finds a novel use for bamboo—as hardy, reusable eco-friendly tableware

■ By Newtly Paul

Fine dining may be synonymous with plush leather chairs, patterned chinaware and polished silver cutlery, but if Assam's Tridib Mahanta has his way, the humble bamboo will soon be gracing dinner tables. Mahanta has handcrafted fine quality bamboo cutlery and its novelty is that it is eco-friendly—completely washable and reusable.

The cutlery comes treated with saturated common salt, which prevents the formation of fungus. Once these forks, knives and spoons have been dried in the shade, they are ready to be used again. The products, he claims, can last up to 20 years even after regular usage.

Mahanta's perfectly finished designs are a result of self-acquired skills and practice. One day in 2003, his daughter began clamouring for a bamboo fork she had seen somewhere. To placate his child, this statistics topper from Dibrugarh University and part-time tuition teacher, sat up at night carving out a fork from a piece of bamboo. The child's delight the following morning set Mahanta thinking.

Armed with Rs 10,000, he spent a year experimenting with different designs and types of bamboo, finally settling on the *Jati* bamboo, the hardest variety of the plant available. Over time, he even designed tools that would serve to



bend and curve his cutlery. Today, Mahanta is a one-man industry churning about 40 pieces a month, saying it takes him three days "and a lot of patience" to complete one piece.

In his early days, he says, "People regarded my craft with amusement and laughed at my efforts, but I was resolute." His first set of six forks was sold for Rs 1,200 and since then business, which he has given the trade name

of Bamboo-o-o-o-s, has been steady. He has a catalogue of 413 designs, which he first showed at craft exhibitions in his state. In April 2004, when he took home Rs 18,500 from showing in Duliajan, a census town in Dibrugarh district, Mahanta knew he was onto something. In Hyderabad, for a 2006 exhibition, he got a chance to interact with buyers from China, Malaysia and Japan. That year he was also awarded the Unesco Seal of Excellence certificate for his eco-friendly range of tableware.

Mahanta's unique cutlery costs Rs 200 and above for one piece and Rs 900 and more for a set. The piece de resistance, an 84-piece-set has been bought only once, for Rs 46,000. Now sponsored by the North-East Development Finance Corporation Ltd, he has travelled in India and abroad, and wants to train six apprentices by 2009 to spread the idea of eco-friendly tableware. The humble grass, he believes, can replace the royal silver spoon. ■